At Fatehpur Sikri, Badauni was presented to Akbar by one Jalal Khan Qurchi, ‘a master of mirth and wit, and a confidential and personal friend of the Emperor’. Jalal Khan introduced the serious young scholar to the Padshah saying, ‘I have discovered an imam for your majesty, whom you will be pleased with.’ This was a crucial interview for Badauni as all appointments to imperial service were made by the Padshah personally, and the rank and salary were determined case by case, depending on circumstances, and a great deal rested on Akbar’s discernment:

> In ordinary cases…a candidate had to find a patron who would introduce him to the Emperor and if he won favour, his appointment followed after a somewhat lengthy series of formalities. There appears to have been no recognized test of fitness… Akbar had great faith in his own powers of discerning character, and he appears to have acted uniformly on his own judgment. In the same way there were no rules regarding promotion; an officer might be advanced or degraded, or dismissed at the Emperor’s pleasure.

Badauni himself admitted that ‘as learning was a merchandise much in demand, I had the privilege of being addressed [by His Majesty] as soon as I reached (his presence). I was included among the members of the assembly and was thrown into the discussion with the ulema… By the grace of God, the power of my mind, the sensitiveness of my intelligence and that boldness which is a natural quality of youth, I often proved myself the superior.’ Badauni, not in the least bashful, also noted that ‘the Emperor, on account of the beauty of my voice, which was comparable with the sweet voice, and ravishing tones of a parrot, made me the Reader of the Prayer on Wednesday evenings, and entered me among the seven Imams.’ Badauni was poised at this time to become a valued member of Akbar’s court. He was undoubtedly knowledgeable in orthodox Islamic literature but he had many other accomplishments which would have been greatly cherished at the Mughal court. ‘Mullah Abdul Qadir,’ wrote Faizi, ‘in addition to his accomplishment in learning, has an inclination towards poetry and taste in prose composition both Arabic and Persian. He is also acquainted with Indian astrology and mathematics. He has knowledge of Indian and Persian music and is not ignorant of chess, both two-handed and four-handed. He has also made commendable practice on the bin (flute)’.